Max & Mia Podcast - Everyday English Conversations - EP 119

INTRO

Mia: Hello, everyone. Welcome back to Max and Mia Podcast. I'm Mia.

Max: And I'm Max. Really glad you're here with us today.

Mia: Whether you're on your way to work, taking a break, or just doing something around the house thank you for spending some of your time with us. It genuinely means a lot.

Max: It really does. Alright Mia, how's the week been?

Mia: Honestly, a bit all over the place. I had a few things overlapping at the same time, so I spent most of the week just trying to keep up. Nothing dramatic, just... a lot.

Max: I know that feeling. Mine was similar, actually. By Thursday I was already running on empty.

Mia: Exactly. And then Friday arrives and you think, okay, finally. Are you doing anything this weekend?

Max: Nothing too ambitious. I might go see a film, sleep in on Sunday. Just decompress, really. You?

Mia: I'm heading out of the city for a couple of days. Some friends, no real plans just getting away for a bit. I think I need it.

Max: That sounds like exactly the right call. Alright, shall we get into today's episode?

Mia: Let's do it.

EPISODE INTRO — WORK

Max: So today, we're shifting our focus to the workplace. And we thought the best place to start is with something pretty much everyone has been through at some point.

Mia: Urgent shift changes. You know something comes up, you can't make your shift, and suddenly you're texting a colleague hoping they can step in. Or maybe someone does that to you.

Max: It happens constantly. And it seems simple on the surface, but the way you handle it actually says a lot about how professional you are, how considerate you are, and honestly, how people will respond to you next time you need a favour.

Mia: So we want to talk about how these conversations actually go, what language you'd use, and how to phrase things in a way that's clear and doesn't put the other person in an awkward spot.

VOCABULARY & LANGUAGE

Max: Let's start with the obvious one. The most common thing you'd say is just "Can you cover my shift?" Short, direct, everyone understands it. That works perfectly fine between colleagues who know each other well.

Mia: Right, and there's also "I need to swap shifts" which is slightly different, because swapping implies you're offering your shift in return for theirs. It's more of an exchange.

Max: Good point. And then you've got phrases like "something came up" which is one of those expressions that's incredibly useful because it explains the situation without you having to go into detail.

Mia: Although it's worth being a little careful with that one. If you use it too often, people start to notice.

Max: Fair enough. Now one thing that makes a real difference is how you frame the ask. Saying "Can you cover my shift?" is fine, but "Would you be available to take my shift?" sounds a bit more considerate. You're giving the other person room to say no.

Mia: And always always offer something back. "I'll cover for you next time" or "I'll return the favour" goes a long way. It shows you're not just asking for a handout.

Max: Exactly. Now, if you want to take it up a notch say you're writing to your manager, or it's a more formal workplace the language shifts a little. Instead of "something came up," you might say "an unexpected situation has come up on my end." It's the same idea, just a bit more polished.

Mia: And instead of "I can't make it," you'd go with something like "I'm afraid I won't be available" or "I find myself unable to attend that shift." It sounds more composed, less rushed.

Max: Same with the thank you at the end. Rather than just "thanks a lot," you could say "I really appreciate your flexibility" because that actually acknowledges what the other person is doing for you.

Mia: And if you've sorted everything out between yourselves, don't forget to loop in whoever needs to know. For example, "Please make sure to inform [name] about the arrangement" that way nothing falls through the cracks.

Max: Right. The earlier you sort it out, the better for everyone. Last-minute requests do happen life happens but they're harder to deal with, and people remember them.

Mia: So the short version: be clear, be considerate, and don't forget to acknowledge that you're asking for a favour. That's really the core of it.

Max: Alright let's hear how it actually sounds. We've put together a short conversation between two colleagues dealing with exactly this. Have a listen.

Mia: Here we go.

AUDIO #1— Richard & Travis

Travis: Hey, Richard. Do you have a second?

Richard: Yeah, sure. What's up?

Travis: So... I hate to ask this, but I'm in a bit of a situation. Something came up at home and I don't think I'm going to be able to make it in on Thursday. Is there any chance you'd be able to cover my shift?

Richard: Thursday... which one is yours? Morning or afternoon?

Travis: Afternoon. Two to ten.

Richard: Hmm. That's a long one.

Travis: I know, I know. And I wouldn't ask if I had any other option, honestly. It's just it's kind of urgent and I can't really move it around.

Richard: What happened, if you don't mind me asking?

Travis: It's my sister. She's got an appointment she can't go to alone and there's no one else who can take her. It's been scheduled for a while, I just... I didn't think it would fall on a workday.

Richard: Ah, right. No, I get it. Family stuff, you can't really plan around that.

Travis: Exactly. I'm really sorry to put this on you last minute. Well it's not super last minute, it's still a few days away, but still.

Richard: No, it's fine. Let me just think for a second. I was supposed to go to the gym Thursday evening but that's not exactly a life-or-death commitment.

Travis: I mean, some people would argue it is.

Richard: Yeah, not me. Okay I can do it. I'll take your Thursday afternoon.

Travis: Seriously? That's a massive help, Richard. I really appreciate it.

Richard: Don't worry about it. Just do me a favour I've got a thing on the 14th, Saturday morning. Any chance you could return the favour then? It doesn't have to be confirmed right now, just... keep it in mind.

Travis: The 14th? Yeah, absolutely. Put me down for that. That's the least I can do.

Richard: Perfect. And we should let Sarah know about the swap she's covering the schedule this week.

Travis: Right, yes. I'll send her a message today. Actually, should I mention it to the manager as well, or is Sarah enough?

Richard: I'd loop in the manager too, just to be safe. Better to have it on record than to have someone show up Thursday wondering where you are.

Travis: Good point. I'll take care of both. I'll send them a message this afternoon explaining the situation and confirming that you'll be stepping in.

Richard: Works for me. Just make sure they have it in writing so there's no confusion on the day.

Travis: Of course. And hey I really do appreciate your flexibility on this. I know it's not ideal to change things around mid-week.

Richard: Honestly, it's fine. These things happen. Just sort it out properly with the schedule and we're good.

Travis: Will do. Thanks again, Richard. I owe you one.

Richard: You owe me a Saturday morning shift, that's what you owe me.

Travis: Done. I'll be there.

MAX & MIA — POST AUDIO COMMENTARY

Mia: Okay, a few things I want to pick up on from that conversation.

Max: Go ahead.

Mia: So the first one is something Travis says near the beginning "I wouldn't ask if I had any other option." That structure is really worth noting. "I wouldn't do this if I had any other choice" it's a conditional that softens the request before you've even made it. It shows awareness. You can use it in so many situations, not just at work.

Max: Right, and it's not complicated grammar, but people don't always think to use it in the moment. It's one of those phrases that sounds natural but actually does a lot of work.

Mia: Exactly. The other one I liked was when Richard said "let me just think for a second." Such a small thing, but it buys you time without sounding unsure or dismissive. A lot of people go quiet or just say "um" but that phrase keeps the conversation moving while you actually process what's been asked.

Max: And it sounds composed. Which matters. The other thing I noticed was the way Travis closed it "I'll take care of both." Not "I'll try" or "I'll see what I can do." He committed. And that's actually something worth paying attention to in English being specific about what you're going to do signals reliability. "I'll send them a message this afternoon" is much stronger than "I'll sort it out at some point."

Mia: Yes, and the difference between "I'll do it" and "I'll take care of it" is subtle but real. "Take care of it" implies you're handling everything involved, not just the action, but the follow-through.

Max: Good one. And then there's "loop in" as in, "we should loop Sarah in." That's a really common phrase in workplace English and it just means making sure someone is included or informed. You'll hear it constantly, especially in more professional environments.

Mia: Worth adding to your vocabulary if it's not already there. Alright should we move on?

Max: Let's do it.

NEW TOPIC — CANCELLING A PLAN OR MEMBERSHIP YOU NEVER USED

Mia: Okay, so we're shifting gears a little. Still work-adjacent, but this one is more of an everyday situation and honestly, one of the most frustrating ones.

Max: Cancelling something. Specifically, cancelling a subscription, a membership, or a service that you signed up for and never actually used.

Mia: Which somehow makes it even more annoying. Because you didn't even get anything out of it, and now you have to go through the whole process of undoing it.

Max: I had this exact thing happen a few months ago. I signed up for some online course platform I think it was during one of those "new year, new me" moments and I completely forgot about it. Three months later I'm looking at my bank statement thinking, what is this charge?

Mia: Oh, I've been there. Mine was a gym. I joined in January, went twice, and then spent the next four months paying for something I was actively avoiding.

Max: The worst part is when you call to cancel and they put you on hold, transfer you twice, and then ask if you're sure you want to cancel because they have a special offer for you.

Mia: And you have to stay polite the entire time.

Max: Which is the real challenge, honestly.

Mia: So, let's talk about the language you need for exactly that situation. Because whether it's over the phone, via chat support, or even in an email, knowing how to handle it clearly and calmly makes a real difference.

Max: Let's start with the basics. "I'd like to cancel my subscription" that's your opener. Clean, direct, no explanation needed at first.

Mia: "I'd like to cancel my membership effective immediately" is a step up "effective immediately" signals that you mean now, not at the end of the next billing cycle.

Max: And "I was charged for a service I did not use" that one is important. If you're disputing a charge or asking for a refund, being specific about the fact that the service went unused strengthens your case.

Mia: Now, they will almost always push back. They'll say things like "are you sure?" or "we have a plan that might work better for you." And this is where a lot of people get derailed. So it helps to have a firm but polite way to hold your ground.

Max: Something like "I appreciate that, but I've made my decision" or "Thank you for the offer, but I'd like to proceed with the cancellation." You're not being rude, you're just not leaving the door open.

Mia: And if they try to delay it "I want to confirm that this will be cancelled today and that I won't be charged again" that's how you make sure they can't backtrack later.

Max: Now, to take it up a notch. Instead of just saying "I want to cancel," you can say "I'd like to request the immediate termination of my account." Sounds formal, but in a written complaint or email, that kind of language gets taken more seriously.

Mia: And "I have not made use of this service since the date of sign-up" again, more formal, but it clearly establishes that you're not getting value from whatever you're paying for.

Max: "I would appreciate written confirmation of the cancellation" that one's useful too. Always ask for confirmation. It protects you if something goes wrong later.

Mia: And instead of "no one told me about this charge," you'd say "I was not made aware of the recurring billing terms at the time of sign-up." Much more precise, and it puts the responsibility where it belongs.

Max: Alright we've put together an audio clip for this one too. Two people, one of them on the phone trying to cancel a gym membership they signed up for and never used. Let's hear how that goes.

Mia: Here we go.

AUDIO #2— Agent & Customer

Agent: Thank you for calling Nextel customer support. My name is Daniel. How can I help you today?

Customer: Hi, yes so, I'm calling because I just checked my account online and apparently I've been put on a new plan? And I... I didn't ask for that. I didn't change anything.

Agent: I'm sorry to hear that. Let me just pull up your account. Can I get your full name and the number associated with the account?

Customer: Yeah, it's Marcus Webb. And the number is 555-0174.

Agent: Perfect, thank you. Just give me one moment while I bring that up... Okay, I can see your account here. So it looks like a premium data plan was added on the 8th of this month. Is that the change you're referring to?

Customer: Yes, exactly. That's I mean, I never requested that. I've been on the same basic plan for like two years, and I haven't called in, I haven't gone online to change anything, so I genuinely don't understand how this happened.

Agent: I completely understand your frustration, Mr. Webb. Let me look into how this was processed... Okay, so it appears the plan was updated following a promotional campaign that was sent out to eligible customers. It looks like the change was applied automatically.

Customer: Wait, automatically? So you just... changed my plan without me agreeing to it?

Agent: I understand how that sounds, and I do apologise. In some cases, promotional upgrades can be applied unless the customer opts out beforehand. There should have been a notification sent to your registered email.

Customer: Right, well I didn't see any email, and more importantly, I didn't opt in to anything. I didn't click anything, I didn't sign anything. So I'd like this reversed, please. And I'd also like to know if I've been charged for it, because if I have, that needs to be sorted out as well.

Agent: Absolutely, that's completely fair. Let me check the billing side of things... So it does look like the new plan rate was applied to your last billing cycle. The difference would be around fourteen dollars.

Customer: Fourteen dollars for something I never asked for. Okay. So what happens now, do I get that back, or...?

Agent: Yes, I can process a credit for that amount today. And I'll also revert your plan back to your previous package immediately. You won't be charged the higher rate going forward.

Customer: Okay. And sorry, I just want to make sure this isn't going to happen again, right? Like, is there a way to make sure I don't get automatically enrolled in something without my consent?

Agent: Yes, absolutely. I can add a note to your account flagging that you do not wish to receive automatic plan changes. Any future promotional offers would require your explicit confirmation before anything is applied.

Customer: Good. Yes, please do that. And can I get some kind of confirmation of all this? The credit, the plan change, everything?

Agent: Of course. I'll send a confirmation to your registered email address once everything has been processed. It should come through within the next hour or so.

Customer: Alright. I appreciate that. I mean look, I'm not trying to be difficult, it's just... this kind of thing shouldn't happen in the first place.

Agent: No, you're absolutely right, and I apologise for the inconvenience. Is there anything else I can help you with today?

Customer: No, that's that should be everything. Thank you, Daniel.

Agent: Thank you for your patience, Mr. Webb. Have a good day.

Customer: You too. Bye.

MAX & MIA — POST AUDIO COMMENTARY & CALL TO ACTION

Max: Okay. A few things worth noting there.

Mia: The first one for me is how Marcus handled the pushback. When the agent said "there should have been a notification sent to your email" which is basically a polite way of saying "it's kind of on you" Marcus didn't get defensive or raise his voice. He just redirected: "I didn't see any email, and more importantly, I didn't opt in to anything." That "more importantly" is doing a lot of work. It moves the conversation forward without getting stuck on a detail.

Max: Right. And the phrase "I'd like this reversed, please" short, clear, no room for interpretation. A lot of people in that situation over-explain or apologise for asking. You don't need to. State what you want and let them respond.

Mia: And then at the end "I'm not trying to be difficult, it's just... this kind of thing shouldn't happen in the first place." That line is a good example of how you can assert yourself without sounding aggressive. You're acknowledging the agent as a person while still making your point.

Max: Which, honestly, also tends to get better results.

Mia: It does. People respond better when they don't feel attacked even if the situation is genuinely frustrating.

Max: Alright. Before we move on if you're finding this useful, it would really mean a lot if you subscribed to the podcast. It takes about three seconds and it helps more people find the show.

Mia: And if you want to leave a review or a comment, we actually do read them. So if there's a topic you'd like us to cover, or something you want us to go deeper on, let us know.

Max: Alright last topic of the day.

NEW TOPIC — BARGAINING AT THE MARKET

Mia: So this one is a little different from the others. Less stressful, hopefully. We're talking about bargaining or haggling, as it's also called at markets.

Max: And this is one of those things that really depends on where you are in the world. Because in some countries, bargaining is completely normal, it's part of the culture, part of the buying process. In some places it's actually expected.

Mia: I've heard it said that in certain markets parts of Southeast Asia, the Middle East, Latin America not bargaining can almost come across as odd. Like you're paying whatever you're told without engaging, which some sellers apparently find a bit strange.

Max: And we'd love to know if that matches your experience. If you're from a country where bargaining is common or where it would be considered really rude leave us a comment. Because honestly, we're curious.

Mia: In a lot of Western countries, though, it's not really the norm. You walk into a shop, there's a price tag, you pay it. Done. Trying to negotiate the price of a jacket at a high street store would get you some very confused looks.

Max: Speaking from experience?

Mia: I neither confirm nor deny. The point is knowing how to do it, and how to do it without making things awkward, is a genuinely useful skill. Whether you're travelling, living abroad, or just at a local flea market.

Max: So let's talk about the language. The most basic version "Can you do a better price?" or "Is there any flexibility on the price?" Both work. The second one is a bit softer, leaves more room for a conversation rather than a flat yes or no.

Mia: And if you're buying more than one thing, "what's the best price if I take both?" is a natural way to bundle the negotiation. You're giving them a reason to come down a little.

Max: "I'll take it for..." followed by your offer also very common. Direct, no fuss.

Mia: Now, to elevate it a bit. Instead of "can you lower the price," you might say "would you consider coming down on the price?" it sounds more like a conversation and less like a demand.

Max: "That's a little out of my budget, but I'm genuinely interested" that one's useful because it tells the seller you're not just trying to lowball them, you actually want to buy. That changes the dynamic.

Mia: And if their counter-offer is still too high, "I appreciate that, but I think we're still a bit far apart" is a very natural way to keep the door open without committing to anything.

Max: "Is that the best you can do?" classic. Simple. Works in almost any context.

Mia: And then there's "we'll call it a deal" which is the phrase you use when you've agreed. It's informal, but it's very natural and very satisfying to say.

Max: It really is. Alright we've got one last audio for today. Two people at a street market one trying to buy something, one trying to sell it. Let's hear how it goes.

Mia: Here we go.

AUDIO # 3 Vendor & Customer

Vendor: Good morning! Take your time, have a look around.

Customer: Thank you. These are lovely, actually. Did you make all of these yourself?

Vendor: Most of them, yes. The scarves and the bags all handmade. The jewellery over there is from a friend of mine, also local.

Customer: Oh, nice. I really like this one the brown leather bag. How much is it?

Vendor: That one is sixty-five.

Customer: Sixty-five... okay. It's beautiful, honestly. The stitching is really nice. Is that a fixed price or is there a little room?

Vendor: There's always a little room. What were you thinking?

Customer: I don't want to offend you I know it's handmade and that takes time. But I was thinking somewhere around fifty?

Vendor: Fifty is a bit low for that one, I have to be honest with you. The leather alone that's not cheap material. I could do fifty-eight.

Customer: Fifty-eight. Hmm. Could you do fifty-five?

Vendor: You're not making this easy for me.

Customer: I'm sorry. I genuinely love it, I'm just I'm also looking at that scarf over there and I was thinking of getting both.

Vendor: Oh, you're taking the scarf as well?

Customer: If the price is right, yes. Which one is that the blue and grey one?

Vendor: That one is twenty. So together you're looking at eighty-five if I do fifty-five for the bag.

Customer: What if I said seventy-five for both?

Vendor: Seventy-five for both... that's quite a jump.

Customer: I know. But I'm paying cash, right now, and I'm not going to talk you down any further after this. Seventy-five and we're done.

Vendor: You know what alright. Seventy-five. But only because you're buying both.

Customer: Deal. Thank you, I really appreciate it.

Vendor: You've got good taste, I'll give you that. Do you want me to wrap the bag?

Customer: Yes, please it's actually a gift for my sister.

Vendor: She'll love it. Here you go. And the scarf do you want them together or separate?

Customer: Together is fine. Thank you so much. This is a great market, honestly.

Vendor: Come back next time. We get new pieces in every few weeks.

Customer: I'll definitely be back. Have a good day!

Vendor: You too, thank you!

MAX & MIA — FINAL COMMENTARY & OUTRO

Max: Okay, that was a good one.

Mia: It was. And I think what made it work was the tone. She was never pushy. She made it clear she liked the product, she acknowledged the craftsmanship "I know it's handmade and that takes time" and then she made her offer. That goes a long way.

Max: Right, because bargaining isn't just about the number. It's about how you approach the whole conversation. If you walk in and immediately offer half the asking price with no context, that can feel dismissive. But if you show genuine interest first, it changes the atmosphere.

Mia: And the move she made bringing in the scarf that was smart. "I'm also looking at that scarf over there" completely shifted the negotiation. Suddenly she's a better customer, and the vendor has more reason to be flexible.

Max: That's actually a really useful tactic in any negotiation, not just at a market. If you can bundle things together, you give the other person an incentive to meet you halfway.

Mia: There's also something worth noting grammatically. She said "if the price is right" not "if the price is good" or "if it's cheap enough." "If the price is right" is a very natural, non-confrontational way of saying you're open to buying but not at any cost. It implies you have a limit without stating it outright.

Max: And then at the end "I'm not going to talk you down any further after this." That's a closing move. She's signalling that seventy five is her final offer, but she's framing it as a kind of commitment rather than an ultimatum. It sounds more like a promise than a threat.

Mia: Which is why it worked. The vendor felt like the deal was fair rather than forced.

Max: Exactly. Alright that brings us to the end of today's episode. We covered quite a bit shift changes, cancelling plans you never signed up for, and haggling at the market.

Mia: Three very different situations, but the thread running through all of them is the same: how you say something matters just as much as what you say. The language you choose shapes how people respond to you.

Max: And that's really what this podcast is about. Not just vocabulary lists but understanding how English actually works in real situations.

Mia: If you made it this far, genuinely thank you. It means a lot that you stuck around for the whole episode.

Max: We'll be back next week with more. Until then, take care of yourselves.

Mia: And each other. See you next time.